

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Higher Education and Research English



Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For faculty, postdoctoral researchers, graduate students, lab managers, research administrators, grant staff, ethics-board coordinators, and academic program leaders.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

acknowledgment

Recognition of another person's contribution or confirmation that a message was received.

analysis assumption

A condition treated as true for the purpose of an analysis.

authorship

Recognized responsibility and credit for creating a scholarly or other written work.

conference Q&A

The question-and-answer discussion associated with a conference presentation.

contribution

A person's or activity's part in producing a shared result.

control

A process, approval, check, or technical safeguard designed to reduce risk.

corresponding author

The author designated to coordinate communication about a scholarly publication.

feasibility

Whether a proposed activity can reasonably be carried out under stated conditions.

future work

Further questions or activities proposed after the current study or project.

generalizability

The extent to which findings may apply beyond the people or conditions studied.

human subjects

People whose participation or identifiable information is involved in research under the applicable definition.

hypothesis

A proposed explanation or prediction that can be examined using evidence.

informed consent

A process of providing relevant information and obtaining voluntary agreement under applicable requirements.

innovation

A new or improved approach, product, or process intended to create value.

IRB

Institutional review board: a body that reviews covered human-subjects research under applicable requirements.

limitation

A condition that restricts what evidence, work, or a conclusion can establish.

major revision

A publication decision requiring substantial changes before a manuscript is reconsidered.

metadata

Information describing data, such as its source, units, dates, and structure.

methodology

The methods and reasoning used to conduct a study or analysis.

peer review

Evaluation of scholarly work by others with relevant expertise.

protocol drift

A gradual or unnoticed departure from the planned study or working procedure.

provenance

The documented origin and history of data or an item.

replication

Repeating a study or test to examine whether a finding holds again.

repository

A managed location for storing and accessing data, documents, or code.

reproducibility

Obtaining consistent results using the same data and methods; conventions vary by research field.

research question

The specific question a study is designed to investigate.

response letter

A document replying to comments or questions and explaining the changes or reasoning.

scope

Defined boundary of work, responsibility, deliverables, assumptions, and exclusions.

secondary use

Use of data or material for a purpose beyond the original collection or primary purpose.

significance

The importance of a question or finding; statistical significance has a separate technical meaning.

specific aims

The focused objectives a research proposal intends to achieve.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Help a group reach a clear next step

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Repair a misunderstanding

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Research Questions and Study Design

A research proposal asks whether a program "works" without specifying the outcome or population.

What outcome would count as improvement, for whom, and over what period? A clearer research question will help us choose an appropriate design and describe its limits.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

02 | Grant Proposals and Specific Aims

A grant draft promises to solve a broad scientific problem using a small pilot study.

The pilot can test feasibility and provide preliminary evidence. It cannot resolve the entire problem. I'll narrow the aim so the proposed work and the claim match.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

03 | Lab Meetings and Data Challenges

A result differs from an earlier experiment, but the lab notes omit a protocol change.

Could we compare the protocol versions and recorded conditions? Please add the missing change to the record so the team can assess possible explanations for the difference.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

04 | Research Ethics and Human Subjects

A researcher wants to reuse participant data for a new question. The existing approval and consent materials have not been reviewed.

Does the proposed use fall within the relevant approval and consent arrangements?
Let's check with the appropriate ethics and data-governance processes before assuming reuse is permitted.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

05 | Authorship, Collaboration, and Credit

Collaborators disagree about authorship late in a project. Their contributions and expectations have not been discussed together.

Could we document each contribution and review the applicable authorship criteria as a group? That will give us a clearer basis for the discussion than relying on assumptions about rank or effort.

Try it again: A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

06 | Peer Review and Revision Responses

A reviewer points out that a manuscript's claim goes beyond its sample. The authors agree that the wording needs revision.

Thank you for identifying this limitation. We have narrowed the claim to the studied sample and added a discussion of generalizability. The response should point the reviewer to the revised passage.

Try it again: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

07 | Data Management and Reproducibility

A shared dataset has variable names but no description of units, missing values, or collection dates.

Could you add a data dictionary covering units, missing-value codes, and collection dates? Those details will help another researcher interpret and reuse the data correctly.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

08 | Academic Presentations and Conferences

An audience member asks whether a small study proves a general theory. The presenter needs a concise answer.

The study offers evidence relevant to the theory under these conditions. It does not establish the theory in every setting. A useful next step would test whether the finding holds in a broader sample.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

US Department of Education: FERPA

<https://studentprivacy.ed.gov/ferpa>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the following prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Vocabulary and grammar prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has four practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

Each starter prompt uses B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-30. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Build vocabulary and collocations

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Higher Education and Research English

Professional audience: faculty, postdoctoral researchers, graduate students, lab managers, research administrators, grant staff, ethics-board coordinators, and academic program leaders

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Research Questions and Study Design

Original fictional case: A research proposal asks whether a program "works" without specifying the outcome or population.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: research question: The specific question a study is designed to investigate. / hypothesis: A proposed explanation or prediction that can be examined using evidence. / methodology: The methods and reasoning used to conduct a study or analysis. / limitation: A condition that restricts what evidence, work, or a conclusion can establish.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: What outcome would count as improvement, for whom, and over what period? A clearer research question will help us choose an appropriate design and describe its limits.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Vocabulary in use

1. Choose four useful terms from the reference. For each, give a plain-English meaning in this field, two natural word combinations (collocations), one realistic example and a likely misuse or contrast. Keep the examples consistent with the reference and avoid jargon that does not fit this occupation.
2. Add four related terms that would be useful in a different common situation in the same field. Label these as suggested extensions, explain how they connect to the work, and flag regional or organizational variation where relevant. Do not pad the list with synonyms nobody would use at work.
3. Start a retrieval round: give one short workplace sentence with a gap and a clear clue. Ask me to supply the best term and explain my choice. Stop and wait; do not reveal the answer or a completed sentence yet. Accept another term if its meaning and collocation work.
4. After my attempt, explain one useful distinction and ask me to write my own sentence. Wait, correct a genuine meaning or usage problem, then give the next retrieval question. Work through four questions one at a time.
5. Finish with a short handoff or message task using three terms, followed by two recall questions I can save for another day. Do not pretend to schedule a reminder.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level